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DYRENES BESKYTTELSE

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Animal Protection Denmark's response on the proposals for a regulation on the welfare of dogs and cats and their traceability

Background
Animal Protection Denmark (APD) has received a consultation regarding the proposed regulation on the breeding, registration, and trade of dogs and cats. The association presents the following comments on the proposal.

Summary
APD appreciates the opportunity to provide feedback on the European Commission's proposal for regulating the breeding, registration, and trade of dogs and cats. The association views the initiative to improve animal welfare for dogs and cats in the EU as very positive. Furthermore, APD acknowledges the incorporation of the latest research and knowledge, which can contribute to enhanced welfare for both dogs and cats.

In various aspects, Denmark has more stringent requirements concerning minimum animal welfare standards for the care of dogs and cats. These standards should be maintained at the current level or elevated.

APD presents general comments followed by specific comments below.

General Comments
APD emphasizes that the proposal must encompass all companion animals kept in establishments, handled, or traded within the EU.

The proposal aims to ensure transparency throughout the lives of dogs and cats, which can help combat the illegal trade of these animals and provide insight into their movements within the EU.

Education requirements and the dissemination of information on responsible ownership to new dog and cat owners are crucial initiatives for ensuring animal welfare, both in commercial and private settings.

Healthy breeding practices for dogs and cats are essential for maintaining a robust pet population in the EU. Therefore, clear EU-level standards for health and welfare in breeding programs should be established. Breeding animals with extreme physical traits or serious health issues that

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compromise their welfare should be prohibited, and the proposal should align with the EU's Responsible Dog and Cat Breeding guidelines[1].

Sale of dogs, cats, and other companion animals at physical markets should be prohibited at the EU level due to the potential for illegal trade and associated welfare concerns. This is particularly pertinent for the illegal trade of puppies from Eastern Europe into other EU countries.

Finally, APD insists that euthanasia of dogs and cats, including kittens and puppies of any age, should only be conducted using recognized methods and by authorized veterinarians or individuals approved by national authorities.

Specific Comments
APD supports the proposal for a ban on tail and ear cropping of dogs and cats but suggests that it should apply universally, regardless of commercial or private ownership, and take immediate effect.

The proposal overlooks the misuse of certain reproductive techniques, such as artificial insemination, in breeds incapable of natural mating or birthing, such as brachycephalic breeds and those with extreme features. APD recommends permitting artificial insemination only under exceptional circumstances, such as to enhance genetic diversity, and stipulates that it must be performed exclusively by qualified veterinarians.

APD views positively the mandatory identification and registration of dogs and cats in certain businesses proposed in the regulation. It is APD's firm belief that to enhance the welfare of dogs and cats in the EU, all owned animals should be marked and registered before puppies reach 8 weeks and kittens reach 12 weeks. Anything less creates ambiguity and loopholes.

APD commends the proposed initiatives for traceability through marking and registration in national databases and automated control for online sales. However, online platforms must not only verify the identification and registration (I&R) of animals but also confirm their association with current owners or suppliers. Advertisements should only occur after verification of both aspects. Placing sole responsibility on purchasers for verifying I&R is insufficient for ensuring accurate traceability. A dual verification system, like Veripet, has already proven effective in countries such as Ireland.

Education requirements are positive, but the quality and content of specific learning objectives are crucial for animal welfare. Clear and detailed guidelines for education and information dissemination to dog and cat buyers about responsible ownership are necessary. Denmark's experience in these areas can be shared with other EU countries to their advantage.

[1] https://food.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2020-11/aw_platform_plat-conc_guide_dog-breeding.pdf
https://food.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2020-11/aw_platform_plat-conc_guide_cat-breeding.pdf

The proposed EU rules on housing and handling of dogs and cats in commercial breeding, pet trade, and shelters are welcome, but they must be informed by the latest research and evidence-based knowledge. Consideration should also be given to Danish regulations on commercial animal care, particularly regarding animal numbers, litters, space requirements, and human interaction.

APD applauds the initiative to include country codes on microchips for cats and dogs, essential for traceability.

Finally, APD advocates for the introduction of a positive list in the EU, regulating which animal species can be kept as pets in private homes. This has already been successfully implemented in several EU countries.

Animal Protection Denmark eagerly anticipates a constructive dialogue on enhancing animal welfare for dogs and cats nationally and within the EU and is prepared to provide further elaboration on the consultation response.